



Crucial cameo: Jitesh Sharma's 24 off 10, including two bold sixes — one flat over cover, one scooped over the keeper — pushed RCB to a vital 190 in the final. AFP

Alongside Josh Hazlewood, Romario Shepherd, Yash Dalal and Suyash Sharma, they delivered time and again in clutch moments. But they saved their best for last, defending 190 on a pitch where runs had flowed all season — before the final, the average first-innings score in Ahmedabad was 219.

The turning point? Krunal Pandya's spell.

Punjab was cruising at 52 for 1 after the Powerplay. But Krunal's subtle variations in pace and turn stifled the batters. His first over went for just three runs. In the next, he dismissed the dangerous Prabhsimran Singh with a clever change of pace — a move that flipped the script.

"Krunal is a big-match player and a fierce competitor. That spell was the defining difference between the

sides," Flower said.

For Patidar, too, Krunal was a constant. "Every time I was under pressure, he (Krunal) remained my go-to bowler... I looked for him every time the situation demanded."

For a franchise that had waited 17 long years, scepticism was natural. But with Kohli at the centre, belief never wavered.

Unlike earlier editions stacked with star power, this was a side built on experience and clarity. There were no single-handed rescue acts — it was shared responsibility. In the past, RCB relied heavily on individual brilliance — from Chris Gayle to AB de Villiers — without much success. This time, it invested in impact players and built squad depth. Mayank Agarwal, Devdutt Padikkal and Tim David shared the dugout with domestic talents like Rasikh Dar and Swapnil Singh. That blend allowed the team to remain competitive regardless of the XI.

Kohli, as always, was the centrepiece. He amassed 657 runs, but perhaps more crucially, offered timely inputs — often during

strategic breaks or between overs — to keep younger players settled. As Patidar admitted, "It was a great learning experience for me. I think he deserves it more than anyone else — Virat Kohli and all the fans."

Wherever RCB played, Kohli drew crowds and support. And when the trophy was finally in hand, he dedicated the win to the fans of

RCB in IPL 2025 Most runs



Virat Kohli

Matches 15, Runs 657, Avg. 54.75, S/R 144.71, HS 73*, 50s 8

Most wickets



Josh Hazlewood

Matches 12, Wkts 22, Avg 17.54, S/R 12.0, Econ 8.77, BBI 4/33